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Validating a multidimensional perspective of brand equity on motivation, expectation, and behavioural intention: a practical examination of culinary tourism

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ABSTRACT

This study presents a brand equity theory of culinary tourism by integrating behavioural theory with the mediation-moderation model. The culinary tourism brand-equity model underscores the value of tourists' expectations as a means to enhance the effects of travel motivation on behavioural intention. This study empirically tests this theory using a sample of 513 foreign tourists and provides evidence that travel motivation mediates the relationship between the four critical attributes of brand equity and behavioural intention. Furthermore, the results confirm the interrelationships within brand equity and reveal that tourist expectations positively moderate the relationship between travel motivation and behavioural intention. Implications for theory, research, and practice are discussed.

KEYWORDS

Brand equity; motivation; expectation; behavioural intention; culinary tourism

Introduction

According to the United Nations World Tourism Organization (UNWTO, 2015), the Asia-Pacific region has the most potential of all world regions. Its tourism market share has exceeded that of America. In 1980, the Asia-Pacific region drew 30% of world tourism. That share increased to 45% in 2014 and is expected to reach 57% by 2030, equivalent to over 1 billion international tourist arrivals. The increasingly large tourism market not only highlights the important position of the Asia-Pacific region but also contributes to regional economic development; in 2014, 57 million tourists contributed USD 89 billion to the GDP, and approximately 2.6 million additional jobs benefitted from tourism industry growth. Compared with other emerging countries in the Asia-Pacific region, Taiwan has an abundance of unique food cultures and a safe dining environment, both of which have gained a good reputation from foreign tourists (Lee, Chang, Hou, & Lin, 2008; Liu, 2014). Moreover, a visit to Taiwan offers a novelty-seeking experience

(Chang & Chiang, 2006). With the increasing influx of international visitors, Taiwan's government has devoted abundant resources and made efforts to evaluate intentional tourism trends by formulating marketing promotion strategies, enforcing the food inspection law and system, upgrading service quality, and promoting the region's unique geological features to attract foreign tourists (Horng, Liu, Chou, Yin, & Tsai, 2014; Tsai, Tseng, Tzeng, Wu, & Day, 2012).

To develop the tourism industry and increase the region's economic prosperity, destinations distinguish themselves to attract foreign tourists and build a competitive advantage over other competitors. Examples of these differentiated offerings are art festivals (Quinn, 2006), bun festivals (Chew, 2009), and wine tourism (Park, Reisinger, & Kang, 2008; Yuan & Jang, 2008). However, although the destinations are variously distinguished, what most attracts tourists and significantly influences their travel decision is culinary tourism (Lee, Wall, & Kovacs, 2015; Smith & Xiao, 2008; Sotiriadis, 2015). Culinary tourism has grown

dramatically because it provides opportunities for tourists to visit working farms, learn to cook particular dishes, and visit food producers who develop attractions to promote their brands, all of which provide different national types of eating (Stewart, Bramble, & Ziraldo, 2008). Boyne, Williams, and Hall (2002) discovered that tourists spend nearly 40% of their travel budgets on food at special events. Furthermore, Lee et al. (2015) found that cuisines that are famous tourism targets for foreign tourists seem to constitute destination brand equity and might be developed into special tourism products. Lu, Gursoy, and Lu (2015) asserted that cuisines may provide authentic and unique experiences that can be shaped into their own brand equity and images in customers' minds. In this sense, the unique food products offered and consumed not only provide customers with authentic experiences but can also increase customer loyalty to revisit (Sotiriadis, 2015). This appeal increases culinary tourism's opportunity to be an important source of marketable metaphors for the tourist, thus reinforcing the attractiveness and sustainability of the destination (Du Rand & Heath, 2006). However, the recent tourism literature lacks a significant body of work on culinary tourism, which highlights the needed to discover a proactive approach in destination branding and adopts a broader perspective of investigating the impact of tourism destination brand equity (Gómez, Lopez, & Molina, 2015). With this proposition, the purpose of our study is to fill the gaps left by previous studies, to identify the critical role of culinary tourism in tourists' travel intention motivation and to understand how destination brand equity and travel behaviour can be affected, which may contribute to marketing strategy creation in the competitive international travel market.

Culinary tourism brand equity is a significant growth area that attracts visitors with unique and unforgettable food and drink experiences (Hornig, Liu, Chiu, & Tsai, 2012). An increasing number of destinations are attempting to promote their cuisine and culinary tradition as "food- and drink-themed events and festivals" to differentiate their offerings and provide attractions for tourists (Okumus, Kock, Scantlebury, & Okumus, 2013). The term "culinary tourism" was initially illustrated by Wolf (2002, P.5), who defined culinary tourism as "travel for the search and enjoyment of prepared food and drink" (Lee et al., 2015). Long (2014), suggested that culinary tourism was not constrained to the purchase or consumption of local food but rather also included

participation in the process of food production or experience in special or unique cuisine. She viewed this participation as a travel destination or an important travel activity. Similarly, Mason and Paggiaro (2012) claimed that food is a means for tourists to fulfil their expectations of experiencing different local cultures without reluctance when they immerse themselves in the culture through authentic and engaging cuisine experiences with local people and other cultural activities.

Past research on culinary tourism highlights the importance of culinary topics as future directions for tourism studies. It also shows an inseparable relationship between culinary tourism and customer behaviour in consumption experiences. Recently, as tourism has become more internationalized, culinary tourism has provided local cuisine and a diversity of enjoyable cultural experiences. This type of tourism has been considered a powerful promotional tool to attract foreign tourists. While culinary tourism is becoming a critical part of the international tourism market and is receiving widespread attention within tourism academia, limited studies have examined the relationships among culinary brand equity, motivation and behavioural intention. In particular, few researchers have used an integrated mediation-moderation model in culinary tourism. Hence, the main purpose of this study is to examine how culinary tourism brand equity enhances motivation and further influences behavioural intention and to discuss the interrelationships among brand equity and the way tourists' expectations moderate the relationship between travel motivation and behavioural intentions in culinary tourism. The hypothesized models are summarized in Figure 1.

Literature review and hypothesis development

Moderation and mediation are prevalent in the recent basic and applied behavioural literature (Edwards & Lambert, 2007; Hayes, 2015). Moderation is involved in research on individual behavioural or decision-making processes that influence the strength of the relationship between a predictor and an intention, such as studies showing that the effects of revisit intention on well-being depend on the destination image's brand equity (Stylos, Vassiliadis, Bellou, & Andronikidis, 2016). Mediation is illustrated by the indirect effect of an independent variable on a dependent variable through a critical mediator variable,

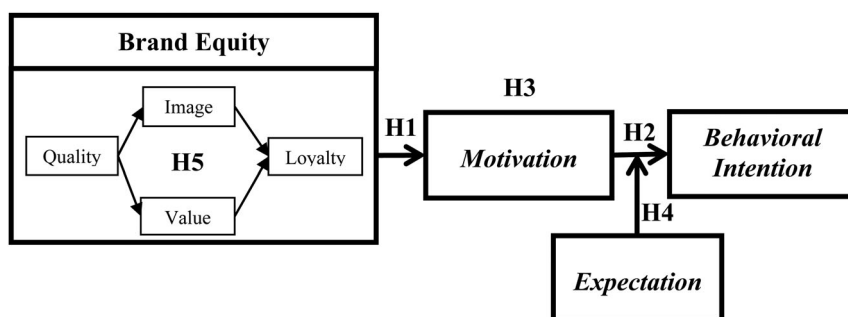


Figure 1. Model linking brand equity and motivation to behaviour intention.

which stipulates, through the theory of reasoned action, that the effects of individual attitudes on behaviour or intention are mediated by motivations (Edwards & Lambert, 2007). To fully illustrate the individual behaviour or intention, researchers often integrate the concepts of moderation and mediation, in which a moderating effect is conducted through a mediator variable (Bajs, 2015). For example, studies examining perceived value as a critical mediator of the effects of perceived quality and motivation on tourist's attitudes have framed revisit attitudes as an interaction between the occupation types that the behaviour will result in satisfaction and loyalty (Lee, 2016). On the basis of tourism studies, tourists' motivation serves as a mediator of the effect of the interaction between attitudes and destination image on word of mouth and visit behaviour (Doosti, Jalilvand, Asadi, Khazaei Pool, & Mehrani Adl, 2016). In other studies of destination brand equity, new analyses are combined as mediation moderated to discover tourists' behaviour such that brand loyalty can mediate the effects of motivation and be moderated by behavioural intention in culinary tourism (Horng et al., 2012). As such, mediation-moderation analysis used in behavioural research provides meaningful information on tourists' destination evaluations (Zhang, Wu, Morrison, Tseng, & Chen, 2016).

Culinary tourism brand equity

Recently, culinary tourism has become a new trend among foreign tourists who seek to understand different cuisines, cultures, social norms, and lifestyles and to acquire unique experiences that they cannot find in their home countries (Horng et al., 2012; Lee et al., 2008). In particular, tourism and hospitality managers have realized that it is important for a tourism destination to build positive brand equity into tourists' travel

memories not only to increase the image in tourists' minds but also to highlight tourism features that can enhance tourists' loyalty and satisfaction (Liu & Chou, 2016). For a foreign tourist travelling to a major destination, destination brand equity might deliver information about reputation, values, cultures and image (Lockshin & Spawton, 2001). Yoo and Donthu (2001) noted that customer-based brand equity enhanced tourists' interpretation and evaluation of destination information, confidence in the travel decision, and satisfaction. Keller (1993) also suggested that brand equity might be viewed as the result of consumers' response to the brand marketing, which might influence tourists' behaviour. Therefore, the development of destination brand equity can prompt a relationship among individual characteristics, tourist personality, destination symbols, the destination image, and organization of awareness and may encourage emotional and self-expression interests (Aaker, 2009).

The central feature of brand equity is the added attractiveness of a product or service that facilitates a brand image, awareness of the destination, perceived value, and enhanced loyalty among customers (Liu & Chou, 2016). Ottenbacher and Harrington (2011) note that culinary tourism can create a unique and unforgettable image for a tourist, which is a powerful tool to promote destinations. Wong and Wickham (2015) asserted that branding is a useful tool to increase customers' perception of the value of a product or service that can effectively communicate its own marketing strategy to tourism firms in the area and distinguish its brand from other destinations. In culinary tourism brand-equity development, an increasing number of tourists are attracted to the experience of unique and authentic culinary products (Smith & Costello, 2009). In other words, increasing memorable food and drink experiences for tourists

not only strongly encourages their travel motivation but also influences their loyalty and revisit intention (Horng, Hu, Teng, & Lin, 2014). Furthermore, culinary tourism should enable researchers to clearly demonstrate the differential effects and interrelationships of brand equity, providing not only high external validity but also an opportunity to identify which factors lead to the various effects of brand equity and its resultant behaviour (Lee & Back, 2010). To extend the theoretical validity of culinary tourism beyond the previous model, this study aims to re-examine the differential effects of brand equity.

In recent tourism studies, four main elements of destination brand equity have been proposed: (1) *brand value*: Boo, Busser, and Baloglu (2009) and Gómez et al. (2015) incorporated a price-based approach to conceptualize and operationalize brand value, which refers to tourists' monetary value perception of the destination brand. (2) *Brand image*: Horng et al. (2012) proposed that brand image refers to tourists' brand perceptions of the functional, social, and sensory aspects of culinary tourism. (3) *Perceived quality*: the perceived quality is more specific (related to particular elements or key aspects), referring to expectations and judgement of tourism products or services provided (Bigne, Sanchez, & Sanchez, 2001). (4) *Brand loyalty*: Nam, Ekinci, and Whyatt (2011) asserted that positive customer experiences are foundational attributes for brand loyalty. When a visitor has a particular experience of a destination, he or she has his or her own unique preferences for the specific destination and experience an increased willingness to recommend the destination to others.

In culinary tourism studies, tourism and hospitality research has presented evidence that brand equity and tourists' behavioural intentions and motivation have a direct positive correlation (Gómez et al., 2015; Horng et al., 2012). In addition, Charters and Ali-Knight (2002) noted that culinary tourism also includes experiencing the local lifestyle in relation to food, art, and culture and can simultaneously help tourists enhance the cuisine values of the region. Long-term economic development and improvement highlights that rural specifics are becoming increasingly important, and building a brand-equity management system based on gourmet products plays an important role that not only can bring goodwill but also might attract visitors to rural areas, thereby further producing economic benefits and increasing employment rates (Hall, 2004). This study considers the above

aspects and focuses on the different attributes of brand equity (i.e. brand value, brand image, perceived quality, and brand loyalty) that are widely used in relevant tourism and hospitality studies and are linked to tourists' behavioural intention and travel motivation.

Direct effect of brand equity and motivation

Based on the foregoing discussion, it is evident that brand management has been a well-recognized management priority for destinations. Particularly in the tourism and hospitality industry, destination brand management requires sharing common cognitive and emotional destination aspects to influence tourists' expectations, motivation, and travel choice orientation (Sartori, Mottironi, & Corigliano, 2012). Culinary tourism destination brand equity has been defined as visitors' preference for the destination, perceived high value and quality, intention to visit, and likelihood of recommending the destination to others (Horng et al., 2012). The destination literature acknowledges culinary tourism as a factor that shapes customers' motivation and value perception. For example, Bianchi, Pike, and Lings (2014) concluded that a positive brand increases the value of a brand and consumers' motivation for a repeat visit. Thus, a favourable brand image of the destination held by visitors is more likely to increase their motivation to experience the gastronomic culture and enhance the value of the culinary tourism destination brand (Long, 2014). This relationship has also been analysed from a tourist's perspective through an examination of the brand equity of culinary tourism destinations as a critical asset that increases tourists' motivation to visit.

Theoretically, travel motivation is differentiated from motivation because motivation is considered an initial driving attribute behind tourism behaviour; therefore, it is likely that tourists' motivation will influence their intention to revisit and their decision-making. Lee (2009) discussed the relationship between motivation and future behaviour in an empirical study of wetlands tourism and discovered a conceptual framework in which future behaviour was determined by tourists' motivation. Baloglu (2000) demonstrated that tourists' behavioural intentions were determined by interrelated sets of stimuli (information sources) and consumer factors (socio-psychological travel motivations). In Baloglu's study, motivation was the most important attribute incorporated into the theoretical framework, and it helped predict tourists' behavioural intentions. Based on the

above literature, the following hypotheses are proposed.

Hypothesis 1. Brand equity is positively related to travel motivation.

Hypothesis 2. Travel motivation is positively related to behavioural intention.

Mediation-moderation hypothesis

Earlier, this paper proposed that there are relationships among brand equity, motivation and tourists' behavioural intention. These hypotheses imply that brand equity indirectly influences behavioural intention through travel motivation. From the travel decision-making perspective, a tourist's unique image, brand evaluation, and perceived value should influence his or her motivation and help him or her make travel decisions and plans to visit or revisit (Kim, Han, Holland, & Byon, 2009). Behavioural intention is a result of a destination evaluation process that requires not only incremental value evaluation of a destination based on the brand image but also the devotion of information searching time, attention, and effort to collect other proprietary brand assets (Kim & Kim, 2005). Lam and Hsu (2006) proposed exploring the influence of destination brand beliefs of push and pull travel motivation on attitude, normative beliefs and subjective norm on the behavioural intention of choosing a destination. Then, the positive evaluation of destination brand equity would facilitate a tourist's motivation and loyalty in choosing a travel destination, increasing the tourist's intention to revisit a specific destination (Chen & Tsai, 2007).

Similarly, expectations might moderate the relationship between travel motivation and behavioural intention. Gnoth (1997) noted that expectations determine perceptions of products, services, and travel experiences and might help tourists categorize destination attitudes, activities, and attraction. As suggested by Hsu, Cai, and Li (2009), the connected relationships of expectation and motivation facilitate the discussion of the expectation, motivation, and attitude model and are utilized when evaluating a destination. Subsequently, a review of the tourism literature concluded that both emotional and cognitive parameters must be included when tourist behavioural intentions are evaluated for considering and estimating a travel decision (Schofield, 2000). Huang and Hsu (2009) also asserted that expectations increase tourists' motivation to satisfy their

psychological/biological needs, which drives their feeling, attitude, and behavioural intention. For these reasons, this study suggests that destination expectations moderate the relationship between travel motivation and behavioural intention.

Hypothesis 3. Travel motivation mediates the relationships between brand equity and behavioural intention.

Hypothesis 4. The relationship between travel motivation and behavioural intention is moderated by tourist expectation.

The interrelationships within brand equity

Recently, destination brand equity has received increased attention in tourism and hospitality research and has been widely empirically examined in the context of wine tourism strategy (Gómez et al., 2015; Lockshin & Spawton, 2001), cross-cultural discussion (Ruzzier, Antoncic, & Ruzzier, 2014), and motivation measures for short-haul and long-haul markets (Pike & Bianchi, 2013). Fewer studies in this stream, however, have focused on examining the interrelationships of brand equity with foreign tourists' behavioural intention in culinary tourism. To address those unsolved questions, this study examines how different aspects of brand equity and perceived quality can indirectly influence brand loyalty through brand image and brand value.

Previous research has highlighted the importance of perceived quality, which refers to a customer's judgement and evaluation about the entire service process in terms of its excellence or superiority (Horng et al., 2012). In a customer-based brand-equity model, Boo et al. (2009) noted that perceived quality is central to the theory that influences tourists' value justifications and destination image perception. Gartner and Ruzzier (2011) also revealed that the perceived quality of a destination positively influenced perceived trip value, image, and behavioural intention to revisit. Cai and Hobson (2004) suggested that successful brand development considers brand loyalty by considering tourists' perceived quality. Hence, brand loyalty must be confirmed through tourists' perceived positive quality of tourism-related services and products. Accordingly, the effect of brand equity on brand loyalty is influenced when tourists' perceived quality is positive through the evaluation of a destination with value added and when the destination engages the customers' hearts and minds (Boo et al., 2009). Accordingly, this study argues that perceived

quality affects tourists' brand loyalty through its effect on brand value and brand-image perceptions.

Hypothesis 5. Brand value and image mediate the relationship between perceived quality and brand loyalty.

Method

Sampling

This study employs as a target sample a group of foreign tourists who had an unforgettable culinary experience in Taiwan. The convenient sampling and purposive sampling non-probability sampling methods were used to collect data from several famous spots, such as Night Market, Taipei 101, Chiang Kai-shek Memorial Hall, National Palace Museum, and Ximending, which are recommended hot-spot attractions for foreign tourists (2014 Tourism Bureau annual survey report).

To calculate the representative sample, the questionnaire produced distributed proportions that were selected from the foreign tourist population reported by the Taiwan Tourism Bureau in 2014. The 95% confidence interval and ± 0.05 sampling error were estimated and suggested by Horng et al. (2012, p. 2612) to calculate the required samples. The formulation is as follows:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Samples} &= \frac{N}{N(2d/Z_{(\alpha/2)})^2 + 1} \\ &= \frac{4,687,048}{4,687,048(2 \times 0.05/1.96)^2 + 1} \approx 384. \end{aligned}$$

According to the formulation, the sample should include at least 384 participants. To collect additional representative samples, six well-trained research assistants with expertise in English and Japanese translation were hired and conducted face-to-face interviews to collect the questionnaires. The reasons for adopting the face-to-face method of collecting data were as follows: (1) to stand beside the participants to answer any unclear questions and explanations of our research purpose. As Horng et al. (2012) suggest, face-to-face data collection not only can resolve the participants' confusion but also may reduce the possibility of misrepresenting the research purpose. (2) To increase the response rate. Simmons and Bobo (2015) compared two different methods, web surveys and face-to-face surveys, and suggested that the face-to-face survey strategy may provide more efficient and offer greater external validity than

web surveys. Accordingly, face-to-face surveys methods were used in this study, with 800 copies of the questionnaire distributed from 1 October to 30 November 2015. Completed questionnaires that fulfilled the selection criteria numbered 513, yielding a 64.12% response rate.

The present sample was represented by an approximately equal percentage of males (46.74%) and females (53.26%). Moreover, since the Taiwanese government opened the tourism market to China in 2009, the number of tourists from China has exceeded that from Japan, and Chinese tourists constitute the largest group of foreign tourists in Taiwan. In this study, the percentages of tourists by country/region were as follows: China (27.93%), Hong Kong/Macau (19.37%), Japan (29.61%), America (2.23%), Southeast Asia (9.68%), Europe (3.35%), Oceania (1.49%), and other (6.33%). The foreign tourist sample included a high percentage of college graduates (58.10%), and the age dispersion was as follows: under 20 years (38.36%), 21–30 years (44.88%), 31–40 years (9.50%), 41–50 years (4.84%), and 51 or above (2.42%).

Measurement items

Three versions of the survey were administered: Chinese, English, and Japanese. The version instruments were originally translated from the English version, and the contents were modified to fit the research purpose. To ensure the reliability and validity of the measurement items, three English and two Japanese professional translators were invited to complete the "translate/back translate" procedure with the guidance of the "double blind principle" (Brislin, 1980). Then, 6 foreign students were invited to review the initial questionnaire and provide constructive suggestions for modification (Yidong & Xinxin, 2013). All constructs for culinary tourism measurement in the survey were assessed on a 7-point Likert-scale ranging from strongly disagree (1) to strongly agree (7).

Behavioural intention

The measurement of *behavioural intention* was primarily constructed based on Mason and Paggiaro (2012). A five-item scale was developed to measure a foreign tourist's intention to keep attending, to spread positive word of mouth, and to recommend Taiwan culinary tourism. The internal consistency reliability values of Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.925$.

Motivation

The measurement of foreign tourists' *motivation* to attend Taiwan culinary tourism was primarily constructed based on Lee, Jeon, and Kim (2011). A four-item scale was developed to measure motivation to obtain mental rest, to enjoy amusements, and to gain new experiences from culinary tourism. Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.878$.

Expectation

The measurement of foreign tourists' *expectation* of Taiwan culinary tourism was primarily constructed based on Lee et al. (2011). A four-item scale was used to measure tourists' expectation to test various delicious foods, experience different food cultures, enjoy comfortable and safe dining environments, and purchase various related food souvenirs from culinary tourism. Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.789$.

Perceived quality

The measurement of *perceived quality* components was primarily constructed based on Horng et al. (2012). A three-item scale consisting of culinary tourism attributes in Taiwan – including excellent quality, improvement, and reasonable prices – was used. Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.866$.

Brand image

Brand image was measured using a four-item scale drawn from Bianchi et al. (2014), which assesses whether the image of Taiwan culinary tourism is consistent with the tourist's own self-image. A sample item is as follows: Taiwan's culinary tourism image is appealing, excellent, unique, and consistent with my own self-image. Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.894$.

Brand value

Brand value was measured using a four-item scale drawn from Boo et al. (2009), which assesses whether Taiwan's culinary tourism offers reasonable prices, is worth visiting, and is a bargain relative to the benefits that tourists received. Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.902$.

Brand loyalty

Brand loyalty was measured using a three-item scale drawn from Boo et al. (2009), Chi and Qu (2008), and Konecnik and Gartner (2007). The measurement assesses whether Taiwanese culinary tourism is tourists' preferred choice for a vacation, whether tourists

advise other people to visit, and whether they intend to visit in the future. Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.874$.

Control variables

Three potential attributes – country/region, gender, and age – were considered because each might affect the tourist's travel intentions. First, tourists from different countries or regions might have different tourism plans and travel behaviour (Sun, Sun, Wang, Zhang, & Gao, 2016). This study created eight dummy variables to categorize the countries or regions of respondents, including China, Hong Kong/Macau, Japan, America, Southeast Asia, Europe, Oceania, and other. The second variable that this study controlled was gender, coded "0" for female and "1" for male. Accounting for gender differences has been frequently discussed in both tourism and hospitality studies (Guimarães & Silva, 2016). Third, Chen and Shoemaker (2014) suggested that a tourist's age is a critical attribute to consider in current and future tourism. This study categorized the ages of respondents into five groups – younger than 20 years, 21–30 years, 31–40 years, 41–50 years, and 51 years or older – to account for age heterogeneity in relation to foreign tourists' travel intentions.

Results

Common method bias

To minimize the common method bias in this study, several indices were examined. First, the interrater reliabilities of all constructs should be greater than the suggested values of .60; as shown in Figure 3, all factor loading for constructs were above .70 (ranging from .71 to .90), indicating that the mean score of all constructs could be used in the estimation (Hurley & Hult, 1998). Second, AMOS 18.0 software was used to test the overall model fit, and a second-order confirmatory factor analysis was performed to measure the scales' reliability and validity. The comparative fit index (CFI), adjusted goodness-of-fit index (AGFI), goodness-of-fit index (GFI), incremental fit index (IFI), and root-mean-square error of approximation (RMSEA) values were used to assess fit. A CFI and IFI that were each larger than .90 and an RMSEA smaller than .08 were considered to indicate a good model fit (Tsai, Horng, Liu, & Hu, 2015). Consistent with the findings in Tsai et al. (2015), the results supported a second-order factor model of image, value, loyalty,

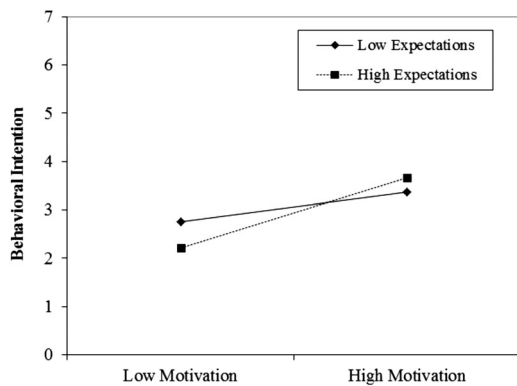


Figure 2. Interactions of motivation and expectations.

and perceived quality for brand equity with the other three first-order factors. The measurement model fit the data satisfactorily ($\chi^2 = 738.927$, $\chi^2/\text{df} = 3.640$, CFI = .946, AGFI = .857, GFI = .885, IFI = .946, RMSEA = .070), and all factor loadings were highly significant ($p < .001$). Third, the factor loadings for each construct were significant and greater than .70, which indicated that the composite reliabilities exceed the suggested value of .60 and that the average variances extracted all exceeded .50, thus demonstrating that the path loadings supporting operationalizing constructs had adequate convergent validity and reliability. Moreover, the results indicated a high correlation among

the measuring constructs; therefore, the values of the variance inflation factors (VIF) were tested. As Table 1 shows, the VIF values of formative indicators of the interactive use construct were less than 4.31, suggesting that multicollinearity between these constructs was not a serious issue. The basic indicators and statistics among all constructs are revealed in Table 1.

Analysis and hypothesis results

Hypothesis 1 predicted that culinary tourism brand equity positively affects tourist travel motivation. Consistent with this prediction, there was a positive effect in Model 1 of Table 2 for brand equity (i.e. perceived quality, $\beta = .107$, $p < .05$; brand image, $\beta = .232$, $p < .001$; brand value, $\beta = .243$, $p < .001$; loyalty, $\beta = .148$, $p < .01$). Hypothesis 2 predicted that foreign tourists' travel motivation is positively connected to their behavioural intention. Consistent with this prediction, there was a positive effect in Model 3 for travel motivation on behavioural intention ($\beta = .798$, $p < .001$).

To test the mediator function of motivation, which represents how brand equity may influence behavioural intention, the procedure of Baron and Kenny (1986) was followed. The first step was to examine the relationship between brand equity

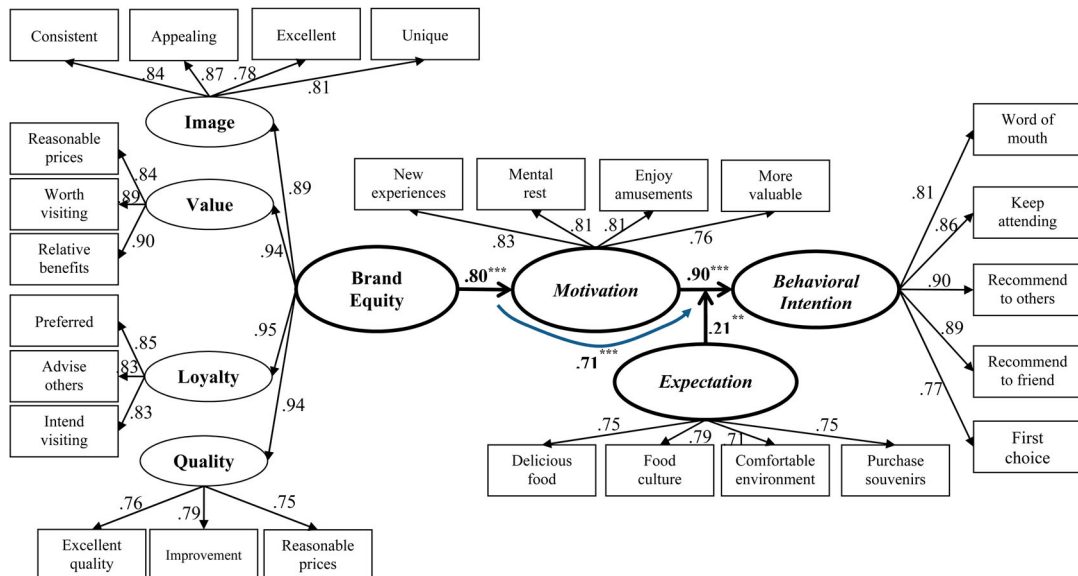


Figure 3. SEM structural model results – full model.

Note: $\chi^2 = 738.927$, $\chi^2/\text{df} = 3.640$, CFI = .946, AGFI = .857, GFI = .885, IFI = .946, RMSEA = .070.

Table 1. Means, standard deviations, and correlations.

Variables	Mean	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	VIF	1/VIF
1. Behavioural Intention	5.539	1.125	(.925)								
2. Motivation	5.539	1.085	.807***	(.878)						4.31	.231
3. Expectations	5.608	1.002	.692***	.778***	(.789)					3.86	.259
4. Perceived Quality	5.240	1.052	.487***	.494***	.536***	(.866)				3.11	.321
5. Brand Image	5.168	1.263	.583***	.594***	.608***	.618***	(.894)			2.83	.353
6. Brand Value	5.429	1.150	.628***	.678***	.702***	.574***	.687***	(.902)		2.33	.428
7. Loyalty	5.448	1.245	.619***	.649***	.686***	.559***	.654***	.846***	(.874)	1.79	.558

* $p < .05$.** $p < .01$.*** $p < .001$.

and motivation. The results revealed a positive relationship between brand equity and travel motivation (i.e. perceived quality, $\beta = .107$, $p < .05$; brand image, $\beta = .232$, $p < .001$; brand value, $\beta = .243$, $p < .001$; loyalty, $\beta = .148$, $p < .01$; see Table 2, Model 1). Second, the relationship between brand equity and behavioural intention was examined and found to be positive (i.e. perceived quality, $\beta = .169$, $p < .01$; brand image, $\beta = .228$, $p < .001$; brand value, $\beta = .142$, $p < .05$; loyalty, $\beta = .180$, $p < .01$; see Model 2). Third, tourists' motivation was

significantly associated with behavioural intention ($B = .789$, $p < .001$), as indicated in Model 3. Finally, as Model 4 in Table 2 shows, the coefficient for the brand equity effects of behavioural intention decreased or became insignificant when travel motivation was counted in the equation. The regression coefficient decreased (i.e. perceived quality from $\beta = .169$ to $\beta = .107$) and became insignificant (i.e. brand image, $\beta = .228$ to $\beta = .077$; brand value, $\beta = .142$ to $\beta = -.014$; loyalty, $\beta = .180$ to $\beta = .084$; $p > .05$). Thus, the partial mediating effect

Table 2. Results of OLS regression analysis of behavioural intention.

Dependent variables Control variables	Motivation Model 1	Behavioural Intention			Sobel test
		Model 2	Model 3	Model 4	
Gender	.104	.312	.261	.245	
Age					
21–30	–.032	–.269	–.232	–.248	
31–40	.149	.013	–.136	–.082	
41–50	.070	–.192	–.214	–.238	
51 or above	.104	.304	.205	.237	
Country/region					
China	–.348	–.559*	–.268	–.335	
Hong Kong/Macau	–.311	–.497*	–.218	–.297	
Japan	–.141	–.414	–.407*	–.324	
America	–.273	–.681**	–.538**	–.505*	
Southeast Asia	–.622*	–.889**	–.447	–.488*	
Europe	–.357	–.431	–.110	–.201	
Others	–.474	–.656*	–.398	–.351*	
Independent variables					
Brand Equity					
Perceived Quality	.107*	.169**		.100*	
Brand Image	.232***	.228***		.077	
Brand Value	.243***	.142*		–.014	
Loyalty	.148**	.180**		.084	
Mediate variables					
Motivation			.798***	.644***	2.807**
Model statistics					
R^2	.535	.531	.686	.710	
R^2_{adj}	.521	.517	.678	.701	
F	37.53***	36.86***	88.18***	74.93***	

N = 537.

* $p < .05$.** $p < .01$.*** $p < .001$.

of motivation on the relationship between brand equity and behavioural intention was confirmed.

An additional robustness indicator of mediation was assessed by the Sobel test. Sobel (1982) calculates the regression coefficient values to determine the mediation effect and its associated standard error of independent variables, and the test has been widely used in previous studies to test indirect effects. The Sobel tests showed that the mediation effect of brand equity positively influenced behavioural intention through encouraging tourists' travel motivation (Sobel statistic = 2.807, $p < .01$).

The moderated models used multiple regressions to test Hypothesis 4, which predicted that tourists' expectations moderate the relationship between travel motivation and behavioural intention. The independent variables of culinary tourism and the moderating variable of tourist expectations were added to the regression equations step by step to assess the degree to which each improved the overall model fit. The results of the regression model are shown in

Table 3. Model 5 is a base model that includes only control variables. Model 6 shows a positive relationship between travel motivation and behavioural intention ($\beta = .625$; $p < .001$). Model 7 shows that the interaction between motivation and expectation is significantly positive ($\beta = .207$; $p < .01$), supporting Hypothesis 4. The interaction between tourists' expectation and travel motivation is more positively related to behavioural intention, as shown in [Figure 2](#), suggesting that motivation is more positively related to behavioural intention for foreign tourists who score high than for those who score low on culinary tourism expectations.

Procedures similar to those of Baron and Kenny were followed to test hypothesis 5. First, as shown in Models 8 and 9 of [Table 4](#), perceived quality was significantly related to brand value ($\beta = .843$, $p < .001$) and brand image ($\beta = .952$, $p < .001$). Second, the dependent variable, perceived quality, was regressed on the dependent variable, brand loyalty. The results revealed a positive relationship between perceived quality ($\beta = .909$, $p < .001$; see Model 10) and brand loyalty. Third, Model 11 shows the results of the mediator and the dependent variable, brand image ($\beta = .717$, $p < .001$), and organizational capital ($\beta = .248$, $p < .001$) had a significantly positive effect on brand loyalty. Finally, the results revealed that the degree of previously significant linkages between perceived quality and brand loyalty became less significant (e.g. from $\beta = .717$, $p < .001$ to $\beta = .163$, $p < .05$; see Model 12) when brand image and brand value were added to the model. However, brand image ($\beta = .680$, $p < .001$) and brand value ($\beta = .181$, $p < .001$) remained significantly related to brand loyalty. The analysed findings suggested that brand image and brand value partially mediated the relationship between perceived quality and brand loyalty.

Table 3. Results of OLS regression analysis of creativity.

Dependent variable Control variables	Behavioural Intention		
	Model 5	Model 6	Model 7
Gender	.293***	.245***	.240***
Age			
21–30	–.238	–.246	–.241
31–40	.004	–.080	–.081
41–50	–.229	–.240	–.240
51 or above	.127	.221	.226
Country/region			
China	–.431	–.329	–.323
Hong Kong/Macau	–.296	–.282	–.271
Japan	–.267	–.311	–.304
America	–.631**	–.505*	–.501*
Southeast Asia	–.715*	–.482*	–.463
Europe	–.196	–.184	–.181
Others	–.352	–.329	–.312
Expectation	.421***	.042	–.057
Independent variables			
<i>Brand Equity</i>			
Perceived Quality	.132*	.098*	.091
Brand Image	.132**	.074	.073
Brand Value	.058	–.018	–.017
Loyalty	.089	.078	.076
Motivation		.625***	.516***
Interaction			
Motivation*Expectation			.207**
Model statistics			
R^2	.588	.710	.711
R^2_{adj}	.574	.700	.700
F	43.62***	70.78***	67.07***

$N = 537$.

* $p < .05$.

** $p < .01$.

*** $p < .001$.

Robustness checks

This study conducted several alternative tests of structural equation models (SEM) to verify the robustness of the results. [Figure 3](#) summarizes the overall model fit and the relationships among the main constructs of brand equity, motivation, and behavioural intention. The values of the chi-square test (χ^2) were significant. Other values for the model fit estimate indices indicated that the overall model was fit for further analysis ($\chi^2 = 738.927$, $\chi^2/df = 3.640$, CFI = .946, AGFI = .857, GFI = .885, IFI = .946, RMSEA = .070).

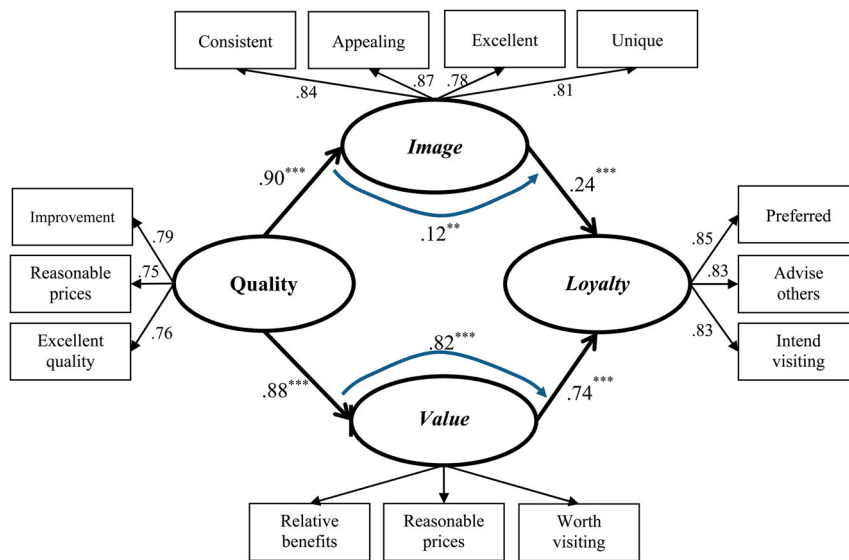


Figure 4. SEM structural model results – brand equity.

Note: $\chi^2 = 266.544$, $\chi^2/df = 4.370$, CFI = .963, AGFI = .890, GFI = .926, IFI = .963, RMSEA = .079.

Hypothesis 1 stated that brand equity, including brand image, brand value, brand loyalty and perceived quality, is positively correlated with travel motivation. The results supported this hypothesis

($\beta = .80$, $p < .001$). Hypothesis 2 stated that travel motivation positively influences foreign tourists' behavioural intention. The results revealed a positive relationship between motivation and behavioural

Table 4. Results of OLS regression analysis of interrelationships of brand equity.

Dependent variables	Value	Image	Loyalty			Sobel test
Control variables	Model 8	Model 9	Model 10	Model 11	Model 12	
Gender	-.061	-.070	-.058	.020	-.004	
Age						
21–30	.074	-.120	-.168	-.176	-.197	
31–40	-.010	-.215	-.161	-.107	-.115	
41–50	-.117	-.283	-.287	-.103	-.155	
51 or above	.145	-.190	-.281	-.329	-.345	
Country/region						
China	-.475	.161	-.831	-.514	-.537**	
Hong Kong/Macau	-.281	.204	-.439	-.271	-.284	
Japan	.376	.304	.187	-.213	-.124	
America	-.585*	-.296	-.990**	-.512*	-.537**	
Southeast Asia	-.366	-.224	.016	.301	.305	
Europe	-.608	.404	-.757	-.404	-.416	
Others	-.521	.063	-.546	-.246	-.203	
Independent variables						
Perceived Quality	.843***	.952***	.909***		.163*	
Mediate variables						
Brand Image				.717***	.680***	2.724**
Brand Value				.248***	.181***	3.411***
Model statistics						
R^2	.522	.638	.509	.754	.760	
R^2_{adj}	.510	.629	.497	.748	.753	
F	44.07***	71.13***	41.81***	114.86***	110.28***	

N = 537.

* $p < .05$.

** $p < .01$.

*** $p < .001$.

intention ($\beta = .90, p < .001$), providing support for Hypothesis 2. Hypothesis 3 proposed that brand equity is positively linked with tourists' behavioural intention through its effect on tourists' travel motivation. The results also supported the hypothesis that certain indirect effects of culinary tourism brand equity affect behavioural intention ($\beta = .71, p < .001$). Hypothesis 4 proposed that the relationship between travel motivation and behavioural intention is moderated by tourist expectations. The nature of this interaction is illustrated in Figure 3, which indicates that tourist expectations moderate the relationships between travel motivation and behavioural intention ($\beta = .21, p < .01$).

Similar SEM examination procedures were used to test Hypothesis 5, which stated that perceived quality is positively connected with foreign tourists' views of brand loyalty for culinary tourism through its effects on brand image and brand value. The structural modelling results shown in Figure 4 indicate that the model fit the data well ($\chi^2 = 266.544, \chi^2/df = 4.370$, CFI = .963, AGFI = .890, GFI = .926, IFI = .963, RMSEA = .079). The results showed that the average indirect effects of perceived quality on brand loyalty were statistically significant through brand image ($\beta = .12, p < .01$) and brand value ($\beta = .82, p < .001$). Thus, Hypothesis 5 was supported.

Discussion and conclusion

This research combines and advances the culinary tourism literatures using a variety of alternative methods to verify how brand equity affects foreign tourists' behavioural intention through their travel motivation. This study developed this model by initially defining culinary tourism brand equity in terms of perceived quality, brand image, brand value, and loyalty. Furthermore, to highlight the critical roles of brand equity in culinary tourism, these attributes were examined conceptually and empirically with travel motivation and behavioural intention. Importantly, the empirical tests also formulated theory from the brand-equity literature that connects culinary tourism expectations to predict tourists' behaviour. Finally, this study integrated the literature on destination brand equity to provide novel insights by examining the multiple dimensions of brand equity with a sample of foreign tourists.

Importantly, the influences of brand equity that were confirmed in this study are also meaningful to predict tourists' motivation. In particular, the results

showed that destination brand equity had a significant influence, explaining 53.5% of motivation. While it is critical to consider mediating relations to realize the effect of customer-based brand equity on tourist destination behaviour (Konecnik & Gartner, 2007), few studies have specifically tested brand equity or encouraged the establishment of these links. The study represents an initial effort in the discovery of the predication of this direction using foreign tourists' experience with culinary tourism. Specifically, the results revealed that brand equity (i.e. perceived quality, brand image, brand value, and loyalty) was indirectly related to foreign tourist behavioural intention through its effects on travel motivation. Thus, the findings demonstrated that tourism managers must increase their attention to developing brand equity in tourists' minds. The findings also highlight the mediating role of tourists' motivation and capture the role of culinary tourism in providing new experiences, mental rest, enjoyable amusements, and value to encourage tourists' behavioural intention. In addition, the findings might also provide a direction for future research to focus on tourists facing specific tourism destination settings, underlining internal and external conditions. Furthermore, within-experience rather than cross-experience studies provide more meaningful results that might allow tourism researchers to better categorize tourist motivation when it requires reinforcement.

Another new insight into the role of mediators explained approximately 79.8% of behavioural intention, leaving few remaining effects of motivation in the tourism and customer-based brand-equity literature. For example, tourism and hospitality researchers have speculated that the brand equity of perceived quality affects wine festival tourists' behavioural intention through its effects on their satisfaction (Yuan & Jang, 2008). A specific tourism destination, particularly in tourism studies, might be related to individuals' motivations and might increase individuals' intention to revisit (Huang & Hsu, 2009; Li, Cai, Lehto, & Huang, 2010). This effect might affect measurements of tourists' travel destination preferences more strongly than searching for information about diverse destinations based on other travellers' shared experiences across different countries or at festival events. For example, with tourism markets open and tourists flowing across countries, travel has become a new trend among members of younger generations. Tourism managers are forced to face changeable situations regardless of their challenges

in attracting foreign tourists' attention. Therefore, managers might develop a responsive and pleasant destination brand equity that encourages international tourists' motivation, fits tourists' changeable needs, and embeds unforgettable travel experiences in their memories to increase their destination loyalty (Yoon & Uysal, 2005).

Moreover, this study found that tourists' expectations played an important role in these complex culinary tourism decision processes by intervening in one particular behavioural mechanism: expectations encourage tourists' motivation and increase pleasant feelings from developing their future behavioural intention. In fact, the results obtained concerning expectation, which is considered an accelerator element in culinary tourism decisions, implies that public and private tourism managers should predict and forecast tourist destinations to fit their expectations. For example, tourists in culinary tourism are likely to view local food, cuisine, and culture; thus, providing various cuisine and appropriate advertisements is a pull factor in promoting Taiwan culinary tourism to domestic and foreign tourists (Horng & Tsai, 2012).

Perhaps most importantly, the findings provide novel and integrated empirical evidence that culinary tourism brand equity encourages foreign tourists to create travel motivation that is conducive to changing their behavioural intention. Specifically, in efficiently developing brand equity, tourism organizations are encouraged to recognize the sequence of brand equity. For example, perceived quality might influence destination choices through brand value and brand image. The attributes considered are a general representation of culinary tourism brand equity, not a comprehensive set applied to other destinations' brand equity. Future research should examine different attributes of destination brand equity and examine how it encourages tourists' motivation and further changes their travel behaviour. Furthermore, the findings were used to analyse the structure of brand equity and provide meaningful results for the tourism literature. The results also confirmed the critical mediating roles of brand value and image; these attributes represent different mediating roles and structures in foreign tourist destination-selecting behaviour. This result provides another perspective and suggests that perceived value influences foreign tourists' destination loyalty when tourists can perceive values and form images from their unforgettable consumption experience during their culinary tourism.

Similar to other studies, although it makes contributions, this study is not without its limitations. Further studies are required to address its weaknesses. First, although this study sampled tourists from different countries to increase representativeness, the sample focused on individuals with consumption experience with culinary tourism. It is possible that culinary and food tourism might exist only as parts of tourist attractions for tourism travel purposes. Hence, future research should examine the generalizability of the present findings by sampling tourism participants across a wider range of countries and extend the findings of this study to other destination purposes. In addition, the measured constructs used in the theoretical model were measured within the same period; therefore, although this study adapted the multiple steps to avoid common method bias, a longitudinal design for data collection is essential to observe the changes in customer needs. Thus, future studies are also suggested to verify the causal relationships depicted in this prediction model with a longitudinal design. Moreover, this study measured brand equity based on tourists' perception of culinary tourism. Although brand equity was found to predict tourists' motivation and behavioural intention, it raised a question regarding the extent to which the subjective measure of brand equity reflected the objective aspect of the travel decision, which is often intentionally designed by previous tourism experiences and expectations. The subjective nature of the brand-equity measure and the measurement of motivation, expectation and behavioural intention potential were also constraints within the subjective measurement. Therefore, a useful next step would be to conduct thorough face-to-face interviews or experiments designed to examine the causal sequences in the relationships among tourists' intentions, brand-equity attributes (subjective), affective experiences, and travel decisions.

Despite the above research limitations, the present study makes several contributions. Although this study limited its focus to foreign tourists, it studied the effects of culinary tourism in a sample in which destination brand equity was extremely important for enhancing tourists' motivation enhancement and influencing their behavioural intention. If behavioural intention is an important issue for tourist travel decision-making, Yuan and Jang (2008) suggested that examining awareness and behavioural intentions among tourists should also yield novel insights or different perspectives for specific events. Furthermore,

given the variance within the sample due to the inclusion of tourists from various countries, the results should be generalized to other contexts of tourism and hospitality, including festivals or events, when capturing different perspectives of foreign tourists. An additional strength of this study was the research design, which obtained data from various language versions of a survey to capture foreign tourists' real feelings about culinary tourism in Taiwan. Because the variables evaluated in this study were collected from foreign tourists with diverse perspectives, the data-handling process prevented the potential effects of percept-percept bias related to the focus on a single region or country (Tsai et al., 2015). Furthermore, this finding is strengthened by the first empirical tests of a mediation-moderation relationship between brand equity and behavioural intention. Most culinary tourism research has not tested the role of mediators and moderators in these relationships because data on multiple countries are difficult to acquire, and such methods are not widely used at present (Hornig et al., 2012; Mason & Paggiaro, 2012). By establishing these important links, this study provides significant contributions that provide a direction for future integrated conceptual and practical work.

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